

Different Quantum Descriptions, Identical Statistics

Mirko Navara 

*Faculty of Electrical Engineering, Czech Technical University in Prague,
Technická 2, CZ-166 27 Prague 6, Czech Republic**

Karl Svozil 

Institute for Theoretical Physics, TU Wien, Wiedner Hauptstrasse 8-10/136, A-1040 Vienna, Austria†

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We introduce quantum pseudocontexts: two separate collections of quantum alternatives that, although assembled differently, give the same total probability for every possible state. This agreement belongs to the chosen quantum description and need not follow from the bare pattern of which alternatives exclude one another. We identify when such examples are genuinely different from ordinary complete measurements, show that allowing phases makes smaller examples possible, and give broad families of examples. The same idea also describes two randomized preparation procedures that cannot be distinguished once their labels are forgotten, or two measurements that agree after selected outcomes are grouped together.

I. INTRODUCTION

Let $a_1, \dots, a_k$ and $b_1, \dots, b_k$ be rays in a finite-dimensional real or complex Hilbert space. The identity

$$\sum_{i=1}^k P_{a_i} = \sum_{i=1}^k P_{b_i} \quad (1)$$

between their rank-one projectors implies

$$\sum_{i=1}^k \text{tr}(\rho P_{a_i}) = \sum_{i=1}^k \text{tr}(\rho P_{b_i}) \quad (2)$$

for every density operator ρ . The two collections need not be orthogonal, jointly measurable, or bases. They are two different quantum descriptions of the same positive operator.

Families with this property arose in the study of probabilistic equivalence between noncommuting observables [1, 2]. Two notions should now be separated. In the stronger, combinatorial notion, a finite set of context-normalization equations forces the equality, independently of a faithful orthogonal representation and of the probability theory [3]. The present paper studies the weaker quantum notion in Eq. (1). The coordinates, or equivalently the projectors, are part of the data. The equality is universal over Born-rule states for those data but need not hold after a recoordination or for classical, softmax-generated, or other probability assignments.

This weaker notion has its own natural theory. It is a problem about equal unit-norm rank-one decompositions, hence about finite frames and positive operators. We establish the sharp minimum genuine sizes over $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$, give continuous constructions for every allowed size,

describe the complete two-dimensional geometry, and organize the general case by the spectrum and commutant of the common operator. A four-ray example will also show directly that quantum equality alone does not imply hypergraph or classical equality.

II. DEFINITION AND OPERATOR EQUIVALENCE

Throughout, $\mathbb{F} \in \{\mathbb{R}, \mathbb{C}\}$ and H is a finite-dimensional Hilbert space over $\mathbb{F}$. For a nonzero vector $v \in H$, we write

$$[v] := \text{span}\{v\} = \mathbb{F}v = \{\alpha v : \alpha \in \mathbb{F}\}$$

for the ray, that is, the one-dimensional linear subspace, spanned by v . The orthogonal projector onto this ray is

$$P_v = \frac{|v\rangle\langle v|}{\langle v, v \rangle}. \quad (3)$$

Thus P_v depends only on the ray $[v]$. For a density operator ρ , the Born probability of this ray is

$$p_\rho(v) = \text{tr}(\rho P_v), \quad \rho \geq 0, \quad \text{tr} \rho = 1. \quad (4)$$

In dimension at least three these are precisely the finitely additive Hilbert-lattice states under the hypotheses of Gleason's theorem [4]. In dimension two we deliberately restrict attention to density-operator states.

Lemma 1 (Separation by quantum states). *If self-adjoint operators X, Y satisfy $\text{tr}(\rho X) = \text{tr}(\rho Y)$ for every density operator ρ , then $X = Y$.*

Proof. Set $C = X - Y$. Since both X and Y are self-adjoint, so is C . Let x be any unit vector. The rank-one projector P_x is positive and has trace one, so it is a density operator. The hypothesis of the lemma therefore gives

$$0 = \text{tr}(P_x X) - \text{tr}(P_x Y) = \text{tr}(P_x C) = \langle x, Cx \rangle.$$

* navara@fel.cvut.cz

† karl.svozil@tuwien.ac.at

Thus the expectation value of C vanishes in every pure state.

Suppose, for contradiction, that $C \neq 0$. By the finite-dimensional spectral theorem, a nonzero self-adjoint operator has a nonzero real eigenvalue μ and a corresponding unit eigenvector u . Hence

$$0 = \langle u, Cu \rangle = \langle u, \mu u \rangle = \mu \|u\|^2 = \mu,$$

contrary to $\mu \neq 0$. Therefore $C = 0$, and consequently $X = Y$. $\square$

Definition 2 (Quantum pseudocontext). A *quantum pseudocontext of size k* in H is a pair of k -element ray families

$$A = \{[a_1], \dots, [a_k]\}, \quad B = \{[b_1], \dots, [b_k]\}$$

where a_i and b_i are chosen unit representatives of their respective rays. This normalization does not affect the projectors or Born probabilities, which depend only on the rays. The rays within each family are required to be distinct, $A \cap B = \emptyset$, and

$$\sum_{i=1}^k p_\rho(a_i) = \sum_{i=1}^k p_\rho(b_i) \quad \text{for every density operator } \rho. \quad (5)$$

It is *genuine* if neither family is an orthonormal basis of its supporting subspace.

Disjointness prevents trivial padding by rays common to both sides. An orthonormal basis of the common support will be called a relative context; it need not be a basis of the ambient Hilbert space.

By Lemma 1, Definition 2 is equivalent to Eq. (1). The common positive operator

$$T := \sum_{i=1}^k P_{a_i} = \sum_{i=1}^k P_{b_i} \quad (6)$$

is the common frame operator of the two families; we call it the *structure operator*. In particular,

$$T \geq 0, \quad \text{tr } T = k, \quad \text{rank } T \leq k. \quad (7)$$

Proposition 3 (Genuineness criterion). *For a quantum pseudocontext with structure operator T , write $\text{ran } T := \{Tx : x \in H\}$ for the range of T , and let $\lambda_{\max}(T)$ denote the largest eigenvalue of T . Then the following are equivalent:*

1. *the pseudocontext is genuine;*
2. *T is not the orthogonal projector onto $\text{ran } T$;*
3. $\lambda_{\max}(T) > 1$.

Proof. We first identify the subspace $\text{ran } T$. For every $x \in H$,

$$\langle x, Tx \rangle = \sum_{i=1}^k |\langle a_i, x \rangle|^2.$$

Consequently, $Tx = 0$ exactly when x is orthogonal to every a_i . Thus

$$\ker T = \text{span}\{a_1, \dots, a_k\}^\perp.$$

Since T is self-adjoint, its range is the orthogonal complement of its kernel. Therefore

$$\text{ran } T = \text{span}\{a_1, \dots, a_k\}.$$

Using the second expression for T in Eq. (6) gives similarly

$$\text{ran } T = \text{span}\{b_1, \dots, b_k\}.$$

Hence $\text{ran } T$ is the common supporting subspace of the two families.

Let $P_{\text{ran } T}$ denote the orthogonal projector onto $\text{ran } T$. If the a_i form an orthonormal basis of $\text{ran } T$, then the usual resolution of the identity on this subspace gives

$$T = \sum_{i=1}^k P_{a_i} = P_{\text{ran } T}.$$

Conversely, suppose that $T = P_{\text{ran } T}$. Since every a_j lies in $\text{ran } T$ and has unit norm,

$$\begin{aligned} 1 &= \langle a_j, P_{\text{ran } T} a_j \rangle = \langle a_j, T a_j \rangle \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^k |\langle a_i, a_j \rangle|^2 = 1 + \sum_{i \neq j} |\langle a_i, a_j \rangle|^2. \end{aligned}$$

It follows that $\langle a_i, a_j \rangle = 0$ whenever $i \neq j$. The a_i therefore form an orthonormal basis of their span, which is $\text{ran } T$. The same argument applies to the b_i . Thus either both families are orthonormal bases of their common support or neither family is. By the definition of genuineness, this proves the equivalence of (1) and (2).

It remains to relate (2) to the largest eigenvalue. Put $r = \text{rank } T$, and denote the nonzero eigenvalues of T by $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_r$. They are positive because $T \geq 0$. If $\lambda_{\max}(T) \leq 1$, then every $\lambda_j \leq 1$, and therefore

$$k = \text{tr } T = \sum_{j=1}^r \lambda_j \leq r = \text{rank } T \leq k,$$

where the first and last relations follow from Eq. (7). Equality must hold throughout. In particular, every nonzero eigenvalue of T equals one. Hence T acts as the identity on $\text{ran } T$ and as zero on its orthogonal complement, so $T = P_{\text{ran } T}$.

Conversely, if $T = P_{\text{ran } T}$, then all its nonzero eigenvalues equal one, and therefore $\lambda_{\max}(T) = 1$. We have proved that

$$T \neq P_{\text{ran } T} \iff \lambda_{\max}(T) > 1,$$

which establishes the equivalence of (2) and (3). $\square$

Consequently, a genuine quantum pseudocontext equates two Born-weight sums that can exceed one. The equality of the sums is state-independent; their common numerical value $\text{tr}(\rho T)$ is generally state-dependent. The exceptional constant cases are characterized in Proposition 11.

III. QUANTUM EQUALITY NEED NOT BE CLASSICALLY FORCED

The smallest genuine complex example already shows that the quantum identity is not imposed on arbitrary hypergraph-free probability assignments.

Example 4 (A non-forced four-ray identity). In $\mathbb{C}^2$, let

$$u_{\pm} = \left(\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}, \pm \frac{1}{2} \right), \quad v_{\pm} = \left(\frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}, \pm \frac{i}{2} \right). \quad (8)$$

The four rays are distinct and

$$P_{u_+} + P_{u_-} = P_{v_+} + P_{v_-} = \text{diag} \left(\frac{3}{2}, \frac{1}{2} \right). \quad (9)$$

The inner product within each pair equals $1/2$, so the quantum pseudocontext is genuine.

Every pair among the four rays is nonorthogonal: the cross inner products are $3/4 \pm i/4$. Their bare orthogonality hypergraph therefore has no contexts and imposes no normalization equation. The assignment

$$q(u_+) = q(u_-) = 1, \quad q(v_+) = q(v_-) = 0 \quad (10)$$

is admissible under the bare-hypergraph convention, which imposes no context-normalization constraints, yet its two sums are 2 and 0. A generic softmax or other parametrization can likewise violate the equality. Equation (9) is guaranteed only when the probabilities are produced from the displayed projectors by the Born rule, or by another model that separately imposes the same operator identity.

This example also shows why quantifying over every density operator does not make the identity coordinatization-independent. Moving the four rays while preserving their empty orthogonality graph will generically destroy Eq. (9).

IV. DIMENSION TWO: BLOCH GEOMETRY AND SHARP THRESHOLDS

Every rank-one projector in $\mathbb{C}^2$ has the Bloch form

$$P_a = \frac{1}{2}(I + \mathbf{r}_a \cdot \boldsymbol{\sigma}), \quad \mathbf{r}_a \in S^2 \subset \mathbb{R}^3, \quad (11)$$

where $\boldsymbol{\sigma}$ denotes the Pauli vector.

Theorem 5 (Bloch-sphere characterization). *Two disjoint k -element ray families in $\mathbb{C}^2$ form a quantum pseudocontext if and only if their Bloch vectors have the same sum:*

$$\sum_{i=1}^k \mathbf{r}_{a_i} = \sum_{i=1}^k \mathbf{r}_{b_i}. \quad (12)$$

The structure operator is

$$T = \frac{k}{2}I + \frac{1}{2}\mathbf{R} \cdot \boldsymbol{\sigma}, \quad \mathbf{R} = \sum_i \mathbf{r}_{a_i}, \quad (13)$$

and has eigenvalues

$$\lambda_{\pm} = \frac{k \pm \|\mathbf{R}\|}{2}. \quad (14)$$

Proof. Substitution of Eq. (11) into the two projector sums proves Eq. (12), because $I, \sigma_x, \sigma_y, \sigma_z$ are linearly independent. The Pauli identity $(\mathbf{R} \cdot \boldsymbol{\sigma})^2 = \|\mathbf{R}\|^2 I$ gives the spectrum. $\square$

For $k = 2$ and $0 < \|\mathbf{R}\| < 2$, write

$$\mathbf{r}_{1,2} = \frac{\mathbf{R}}{2} \pm \mathbf{w}, \quad \mathbf{w} \perp \mathbf{R}, \quad \|\mathbf{w}\|^2 = 1 - \frac{\|\mathbf{R}\|^2}{4}. \quad (15)$$

Thus the unordered two-point decompositions of a fixed nonzero $\mathbf{R}$ form a circle. Example 4 selects two points on this circle of decompositions.

The real projective line is different. A real ray represented by $x_{\theta} = (\cos \theta, \sin \theta)$ has

$$P_{\theta} = \frac{1}{2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 + \cos 2\theta & \sin 2\theta \\ \sin 2\theta & 1 - \cos 2\theta \end{pmatrix}. \quad (16)$$

It is therefore represented by a point $q_{\theta} = (\cos 2\theta, \sin 2\theta)$ on a circle rather than by the full Bloch sphere.

Proposition 6 (Real rigidity at size two). *No genuine quantum pseudocontext of size $k = 2$ exists in a real finite-dimensional Hilbert space.*

Proof. The common range of two equal two-projector sums has dimension at most two, and it cannot be one-dimensional: in a one-dimensional range all four projectors would have the same ray, contrary to distinctness and disjointness. It is therefore enough to work in $\mathbb{R}^2$. Equality is equivalent, by Eq. (16), to equality of two sums of unit vectors on the doubled-angle circle. If unit vectors x, y satisfy $x + y = s \neq 0$, then

$$\begin{aligned} x &= \frac{s}{2} + w, & y &= \frac{s}{2} - w, \\ w &\perp s, & \|w\|^2 &= 1 - \frac{\|s\|^2}{4}. \end{aligned}$$

In the plane, w is determined up to sign, which only exchanges x and y . Thus a nonzero vector has a unique decomposition into two unit circle points, up to permutation, and the two ray pairs coincide. If the common doubled-angle vector sum is zero, each pair is antipodal on the doubled-angle circle, which means that the original rays are orthogonal. Both pairs are then relative contexts and the construction is not genuine. $\square$

The geometric reason is codimension: the complex Bloch sphere offers a circle of chords with a fixed midpoint, while the real Bloch circle offers only one such chord.

V. CONSTRUCTIONS OF EVERY ALLOWED SIZE

The complex size-two phase freedom extends uniformly to all sizes.

Theorem 7 (Complex phase construction). *Let H contain an orthonormal pair e_1, e_2 , let $k \geq 2$, and put $\omega = e^{2\pi i/k}$. Choose $\alpha \in (0, \pi/2)$ and a phase $e^{i\phi}$ that is not a k th root of unity. For $j = 0, \dots, k-1$, define*

$$\begin{aligned} a_j &= \cos \alpha e_1 + \sin \alpha \omega^j e_2, \\ b_j &= \cos \alpha e_1 + \sin \alpha e^{i\phi} \omega^j e_2. \end{aligned} \quad (17)$$

Then all $2k$ rays are distinct and

$$\sum_{j=0}^{k-1} P_{a_j} = \sum_{j=0}^{k-1} P_{b_j} = k(\cos^2 \alpha P_{e_1} + \sin^2 \alpha P_{e_2}). \quad (18)$$

The quantum pseudocontext is genuine whenever $k \geq 3$, and also for $k = 2$ provided $\alpha \neq \pi/4$.

Proof. In each projector, the diagonal terms are $\cos^2 \alpha P_{e_1} + \sin^2 \alpha P_{e_2}$. The off-diagonal terms are proportional to ω^j or ω^{-j} and vanish upon summation because $\sum_{j=0}^{k-1} \omega^j = 0$. The additional phase in the b -family does not affect this cancellation.

Comparison of the nonzero e_1 components shows that two vectors in Eq. (17) can span the same ray only if their second components agree. Powers of ω distinguish rays within each family, and the assumption on $e^{i\phi}$ excludes cross-family collisions. For $k \geq 3$, a k -element family in a two-dimensional support cannot be a basis. For $k = 2$, the inner product within each pair is $\cos 2\alpha$, which is nonzero exactly when $\alpha \neq \pi/4$. $\square$

At $\alpha = \pi/4$, the common operator is $(k/2)I$ on the support. For $k \geq 3$ this is a pair of unit-norm tight frames; for $k = 2$ both families are orthonormal bases and hence nongenuine.

Genuine real examples exist from size three onward. Let

$$\begin{aligned} \theta_j &= \theta_0 + \frac{\pi j}{k}, & x_j &= (\cos \theta_j, \sin \theta_j), \\ & & j &= 0, \dots, k-1. \end{aligned} \quad (19)$$

The doubled-angle points form a regular k -gon and sum to zero. A second copy rotated by $\delta \not\equiv m\pi/k \pmod{\pi}$ is ray-disjoint and has the same zero centroid. Therefore both projector sums equal $(k/2)I_2$. For $k \geq 3$ the two families form a genuine real quantum pseudocontext.

Example 8 (Mercedes-Benz pair). For $k = 3$, take ray directions $0, 2\pi/3, 4\pi/3$ and rotate the second triple by an angle θ that produces no ray collision. Both sums equal $(3/2)I_2$. Figure 1 shows the choice $\theta = \pi/6$.

Combining these constructions with Proposition 6 gives the sharp field-dependent threshold.

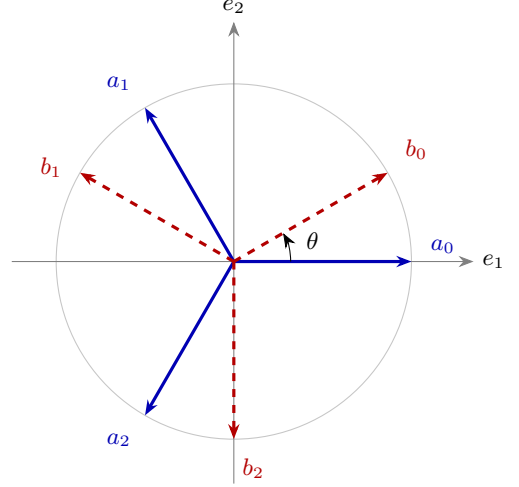


FIG. 1. A real size-three genuine quantum pseudocontext, drawn for $\theta = \pi/6$. The two triples are distinct tight frames with common structure operator $(3/2)I_2$.

Corollary 9 (Minimum genuine size). *The minimum size of a genuine quantum pseudocontext is 2 over $\mathbb{C}$ and 3 over $\mathbb{R}$.*

No size-one example exists over either field, because equality of two rank-one projectors means equality of their rays, contradicting disjointness.

VI. STRUCTURE OPERATORS, GRAM MATRICES, AND SCHUR-HORN THEORY

Let $A : \mathbb{F}^k \rightarrow H$ be the synthesis operator whose columns are unit vectors $a_1, \dots, a_k$. Its frame operator and Gram matrix are

$$T = AA^\dagger, \quad G = A^\dagger A = (\langle a_i, a_j \rangle)_{i,j=1}^k. \quad (20)$$

The nonzero spectra of T and G agree, including multiplicities. In particular,

$$\text{tr } T = k, \quad (21)$$

$$\text{tr}(T^2) = \sum_{i,j=1}^k |\langle a_i, a_j \rangle|^2 = k + \sum_{i \neq j} |\langle a_i, a_j \rangle|^2. \quad (22)$$

Equation (22) gives another proof that a nonorthogonal family has $\lambda_{\max}(T) > 1$.

Which positive operators occur as sums of k unit rank-one projectors? The answer is especially simple.

Theorem 10 (Unit-norm rank-one decompositions). *A positive operator T admits a decomposition*

$$T = \sum_{j=1}^k P_{a_j}, \quad \|a_j\| = 1, \quad (23)$$

if and only if

$$\text{tr } T = k, \quad \text{rank } T \leq k. \quad (24)$$

This statement allows repeated rays; distinctness is an additional condition for quantum pseudocontexts. The assertion holds over both $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$.

Proof. Necessity is Eq. (7). Conversely, let the positive eigenvalues of T be $\lambda_1 \geq \dots \geq \lambda_r > 0$ and pad this list with $k - r$ zeros. The resulting decreasing k -vector has average one, hence majorizes $(1, \dots, 1)$: for each $m \leq k$, the average of its m largest entries is at least its overall average one, and therefore $\sum_{j=1}^m \lambda_j \geq m$. By the Schur–Horn theorem [5], using its real symmetric version when $\mathbb{F} = \mathbb{R}$, there is a positive semidefinite $k \times k$ Gram matrix with this spectrum and diagonal $(1, \dots, 1)$. Factoring the Gram matrix produces k unit vectors whose frame operator has the same nonzero eigenvalues as T ; a unitary or orthogonal identification of the corresponding eigenspaces then gives a decomposition of T itself. $\square$

Now fix a positive operator T satisfying Eq. (24). Let $r = \text{rank } T$, and let $\lambda_1 \geq \dots \geq \lambda_r > 0$ be its nonzero eigenvalues. Fix an orthonormal eigenbasis of $\text{supp } T$ and set $\Lambda := \text{diag}(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_r)$. For a decomposition (23), let $M \in \mathbb{F}^{r \times k}$ be the coordinate matrix of its synthesis operator in this eigenbasis. Then

$$MM^\dagger = \Lambda, \quad \|m_j\| = 1 \quad (j = 1, \dots, k), \quad (25)$$

where m_j is its j th column. Equivalently,

$$M = \Lambda^{1/2} V, \quad VV^\dagger = I_r, \quad \text{diag}(V^\dagger \Lambda V) = \mathbf{1}. \quad (26)$$

A quantum pseudocontext is a pair of points in this decomposition space whose ray sets are internally distinct and mutually disjoint, modulo column phases (signs over $\mathbb{R}$) and permutations.

The eigenvalues of T also give the exact range of the common statistic:

$$\lambda_{\min}(T) \leq \text{tr}(\rho T) \leq \lambda_{\max}(T), \quad (27)$$

where the endpoints are attained on eigenstates. If the ambient space is larger than $\text{supp } T$, then $\lambda_{\min}(T) = 0$ on the full space. On the support, the lower endpoint is the smallest positive eigenvalue. Every intermediate value is obtained by a convex mixture of eigenstates associated with the endpoint eigenvalues.

Proposition 11 (Constancy of the common value). *Let T be the structure operator of a quantum pseudocontext of size k . Put*

$$S := \text{supp } T = \text{ran } T, \quad r := \text{rank } T, \quad n := \dim H.$$

1. *The value $\text{tr}(\rho T)$ is constant over all density operators ρ with $\text{supp } \rho \subseteq S$ if and only if*

$$T = \frac{k}{r} P_S.$$

Equivalently, both families are unit-norm tight frames for S .

2. *The value $\text{tr}(\rho T)$ is constant over all density operators on H if and only if*

$$T = \frac{k}{n} I_H.$$

In particular, this requires $r = n$.

In case (1), the pseudocontext is genuine if and only if $k > r$.

Proof. If $T = cP_S$ and $\text{supp } \rho \subseteq S$, then $\text{tr}(\rho T) = c \text{tr } \rho = c$. Taking traces gives $cr = k$, so $c = k/r$. Conversely, suppose that $\text{tr}(\rho T) = c$ for every density operator supported on S . Taking $\rho = P_x$ for each unit vector $x \in S$ gives

$$\langle x, (T - cP_S)x \rangle = 0.$$

The self-adjoint operator $T|_S - cI_S$ therefore has vanishing quadratic form and is zero. Since T vanishes on $S^\perp$, this gives $T = cP_S$, and the trace again yields $c = k/r$. This proves (1).

If $T = (k/n)I_H$, then $\text{tr}(\rho T) = k/n$ for every density operator on H . Conversely, if this value is constant on all density operators, the same pure-state argument on H gives $T = cI_H$. Its trace yields $c = k/n$, and T has full rank. This proves (2).

Finally, in case (1), $\lambda_{\max}(T) = k/r$. Proposition 3 therefore shows that the pseudocontext is genuine exactly when $k/r > 1$, or equivalently when $k > r$. $\square$

VII. SYMMETRY AND FULL-SUPPORT REAL FAMILIES

If U is unitary (orthogonal over $\mathbb{R}$) and commutes with T , then

$$\sum_i P_{Ua_i} = U \left(\sum_i P_{a_i} \right) U^\dagger = T. \quad (28)$$

Thus the isometric commutant

$$\mathcal{C}_{\mathbb{F}}(T) = \{U : U^\dagger U = I, UT = TU\} \quad (29)$$

acts on the decomposition space. If the distinct eigenspaces of T have dimensions m_α , then

$$\mathcal{C}_{\mathbb{C}}(T) \cong \prod_\alpha U(m_\alpha), \quad \mathcal{C}_{\mathbb{R}}(T) \cong \prod_\alpha O(m_\alpha). \quad (30)$$

Positive spectral degeneracy therefore supplies continuous spatial freedom. Even for a simple positive spectrum, the complex commutant contains independent phase rotations of the one-dimensional eigenspaces, which generically move the rays; the corresponding real commutant on the support is discrete.

The maximally symmetric case is a distinct-ray unit-norm tight frame in dimension $n \geq 2$:

$$T = \sum_{i=1}^k P_{a_i} = \frac{k}{n} I_n. \quad (31)$$

Every $R \in O(n)$ preserves this operator. Apart from the finite union of subvarieties on which some Ra_j collides with an original ray, a rotation therefore gives a disjoint second decomposition. If $k > n$, neither family can be a basis, so the resulting quantum pseudocontext is genuine.

Example 12 (Tetrahedral quantum pseudocontext). In $\mathbb{R}^3$, let

$$\begin{aligned} a_1 &= (0, 0, 1), \\ a_2 &= \left(\frac{2\sqrt{2}}{3}, 0, -\frac{1}{3} \right), \\ a_3 &= \left(-\frac{\sqrt{2}}{3}, \frac{\sqrt{6}}{3}, -\frac{1}{3} \right), \\ a_4 &= \left(-\frac{\sqrt{2}}{3}, -\frac{\sqrt{6}}{3}, -\frac{1}{3} \right). \end{aligned} \quad (32)$$

These vectors form a regular tetrahedral tight frame with

$$\sum_{j=1}^4 P_{a_j} = \frac{4}{3} I_3. \quad (33)$$

Let R be the quarter-turn about the x axis,

$$R = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad b_j = Ra_j. \quad (34)$$

No b_j is collinear with an a_i , and $\sum_j P_{b_j} = (4/3)I_3$. The eight rays therefore form a genuine, full-support real quantum pseudocontext of size four.

The same mechanism applies to any distinct-ray unit-norm tight frame in dimension $n \geq 2$: a generic collision-free orthogonal or unitary transformation produces a disjoint second decomposition. It does not produce a genuine size-three example spanning $\mathbb{R}^3$: if three unit vectors satisfy $\sum_{i=1}^3 P_{a_i} = I_3$, then Eq. (22) forces all off-diagonal inner products to vanish. They are an orthonormal basis. Full-support real size-three examples must therefore have nonscalar structure operators; concrete instances occur in Ref. [1].

VIII. OPERATIONAL MEANING

The projectors within one family generally do not commute and cannot be measured together as one sharp test. The statistic

$$\rho \mapsto \sum_i \text{tr}(\rho P_{a_i}) = \text{tr}(\rho T) \quad (35)$$

is estimated from separate compatible measurement arrangements on repeated preparations. Its equivalence with the b -statistic is exact for every quantum state.

The same identity has a preparation-side reading. By Eq. (7),

$$\rho_T := \frac{T}{k} = \frac{1}{k} \sum_{i=1}^k P_{a_i} = \frac{1}{k} \sum_{i=1}^k P_{b_i} \quad (36)$$

is a density operator. Thus a quantum pseudocontext also specifies two ray-disjoint, equal-cardinality, uniformly weighted pure-state ensembles with the same average state. Over $\mathbb{C}$, this is a constrained instance of the Hughston–Jozsa–Wootters classification of pure-state ensembles of a fixed density operator [6]: here the two decompositions additionally have the same cardinality and uniform weights, and their ray sets are disjoint. Once the preparation label is discarded, no quantum measurement on the system alone can distinguish which of the two randomization procedures produced it, although their labelled fine-grained data remain different.

There is also a direct positive operator-valued measure (POVM) formulation. Since $0 \leq T \leq kI$, the effects

$$\begin{aligned} E_i &= \frac{1}{k} P_{a_i}, & E_0 &= I - \frac{1}{k} T, \\ F_i &= \frac{1}{k} P_{b_i}, & F_0 &= I - \frac{1}{k} T \end{aligned} \quad (37)$$

define two POVMs. Their non-residual outcomes have the same coarse-grained effect T/k . If $T = (k/r)I$ on an r -dimensional support, the more natural normalization $(r/k)P_{a_i}$ removes the residual effect on that support and gives two rank-one tight-frame POVMs.

Equations (36) and (37) are dual operational uses of the same projector identity: it generates a preparation equivalence after randomization and a measurement equivalence after coarse-graining. Neither statement identifies the individual labelled preparations or outcomes.

State-independence also supplies a null consistency test. For two laboratory implementations intended to realize the displayed ray families, the signed difference

$$\Delta(\rho) := \sum_i \text{tr}(\rho P_{a_i}) - \sum_i \text{tr}(\rho P_{b_i}) \quad (38)$$

must vanish for every fixed, otherwise unknown input state. Comparing the two empirical sums therefore requires neither state tomography nor prior knowledge of ρ . A statistically significant nonzero value diagnoses a failure among the assumed projectors, relative detector responses, source stationarity, or the quantum model; by itself it neither localizes the fault nor certifies nonclassicality.

There is an analogous decomposition-level consequence outside the immediate measurement setting. If T is regarded as a positive Hamiltonian written as a sum of rank-one terms, the two ray families give disjoint term lists with exactly the same Hamiltonian and hence the same spectrum and time evolution. Additional implementation constraints, such as locality, may make one

list preferable, but observations of T alone cannot identify which decomposition was used.

This equivalence is related to, but is not by itself, generalized contextuality in the sense of Spekkens [7]. Nor is it a Kochen–Specker contradiction. The four-ray assignment (10) demonstrates that an ontological or classical model is under no obligation to respect the quantum identity unless the equality is added as an operational equivalence or follows independently from its own admissibility constraints.

IX. RELATION TO HYPERGRAPH-FORCED PSEUDOCONTEXTS

In standard graph-theoretic terminology, a *faithful orthogonal representation* (FOR), also called a faithful coordinatization, assigns distinct rays to the vertices so that two rays are orthogonal exactly when the corresponding vertices share a hyperedge [8–10]. More precisely, suppose that the equality of two probability sums is obtained as a balanced linear combination of full-context normalization equations. Under a FOR, every full context is represented by an orthonormal basis and its projectors resolve the identity. Applying the same balanced linear combination to these projector resolutions yields the corresponding projector-sum equality. Thus every hypergraph-forced pseudocontext in this sense whose hypergraph admits a FOR yields a quantum pseudocontext. The converse fails for the induced bare orthogonality hypergraph: a projector identity need not follow from its own orthogonality relations. Example 4 has no bare context equations, and a generic tight frame paired with a generic rotation also carries too little bare orthogonality data to imply its projector-sum identity.

Whether a given identity can be forced after adjoining finitely many auxiliary vertices and contexts is a separate completion problem, not part of Definition 2. A complex three-dimensional size-two completion and its field-dependent realizability are studied in Ref. [11]; the general finite-completion question remains open.

X. OPEN PROBLEMS

Open Problem 13 (Decomposition moduli). For a fixed positive T , determine the connected components and singular strata of the unit-norm decomposition space in Eq. (25), modulo column phases, permutations, and the isometric commutant of T .

Open Problem 14 (Disjoint decomposition criterion). Strengthen Theorem 10 from the existence of one unit-norm decomposition to a spectral or geometric criterion for two ray-disjoint decompositions, over both $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$.

Open Problem 15 (Finite forcing completion). Characterize those quantum pseudocontexts that admit a finite auxiliary context hypergraph whose normalization equations force their equality. In particular, determine which generic tight-frame rotations have such a completion.

XI. CONCLUSION

Quantum pseudocontexts are pairs of disjoint unit-norm rank-one decompositions of one positive operator. Dividing that operator by the common family size gives two uniform pure-state ensembles of one density operator; normalizing the summands as effects gives two POVMs with a common coarse-graining. Their defining equality holds for all density operators because quantum states separate self-adjoint operators. This universality is internal to the chosen quantum coordinatization: it does not make the equality a consequence of a bare orthogonality hypergraph and does not constrain arbitrary classical or softmax probabilities.

The distinction exposes a clean mathematical structure. In $\mathbb{C}^2$, equal projector sums are equal Bloch centroids; complex phase freedom permits genuine examples of size two, while real doubled-angle geometry excludes genuine examples of that size. Schur–Horn theory describes the possible structure operators, their canonical fibers describe all unit-norm decompositions, and spectral degeneracy generates continuous families through the commutant. These operator-level identities are useful as quantum equivalences in their own right, independently of whether any finite hypergraph can force them.

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